

The Road to the American Revolution

Follow the chain of taxes, protests, and reactions from 1763 to 1775 and decide which link did the most to turn disagreement into war.

? Historical challenge

The American Revolution did not begin with a single event. Between 1763 and 1775, a chain of British taxes and colonial protests — each answered by a sharper reaction — pushed the colonies toward war. Trace the chain from pressure to consequence, and decide which link mattered most.

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Roots of Rebellion – National Archives Museum

PRIMARY SOURCE

Documents from the years of rising tension before the war.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the Proclamation of 1763 do?
- Why would that anger colonists?

SOURCES 2

April 19, 1775 – Minute Man National Historical Park (NPS)

SECONDARY SOURCE

The first battles at Lexington Green and Concord's North Bridge.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- Why did British troops march to Concord?
- How did the fighting spread?

SOURCES 3

'No Taxation Without Representation' – Library of Congress

SECONDARY SOURCE

How colonists argued that taxes required their consent through their own representatives.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did 'no taxation without representation' mean?
- How did colonists act on that idea?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

PRESSURE

Proclamation of 1763 — after the French and Indian War, colonists are barred from settling west of the Appalachians.

**ACTION**

Stamp Act 1765 taxes printed materials directly, sparking 'no taxation without representation'; the Townshend Acts (1767) renew the fight.

**REACTION**

Boston Massacre (March 1770) — British soldiers fire into a crowd, killing five colonists; it becomes a rallying point.

**ESCALATION**

Tea Act → Boston Tea Party (Dec. 1773) — colonists dump 342 chests of British tea into Boston Harbor.

**EVENT**

Coercive (Intolerable) Acts (1774) close Boston's port and punish Massachusetts; the First Continental Congress unites the colonies.

**CONSEQUENCES**

Lexington and Concord (April 19, 1775) — the first shots of the Revolution; war begins.

Where might events have gone differently?

People / groups responsible

Sons of Liberty — organized protest and boycotts

Which link was most important?

What if Parliament had repealed the Coercive Acts and seated colonial representatives — could compromise in 1774 have prevented war? (Parliament had backed down before, repealing the Stamp Act in 1766.)

Samuel Adams — Boston organizer and agitator

King George III and Parliament — issued the taxes and the Coercive Acts

Colonial militia (Minutemen) — fought at Lexington and Concord

Of all these links, which single event did the MOST to turn disagreement into war? Cite evidence from the chain to defend your choice — and explain why the links before it were not enough on their own.

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your chains with a partner. Did you order the links the same way?
- Did you choose the same 'most important link'? Defend your choice with evidence.

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

TEACHER NOTE

Key ideas

The road to revolution was a chain of British revenue measures and colonial protests, each escalating the last: the Proclamation of 1763; the Stamp and Townshend Acts; the Boston Massacre (1770); the Boston Tea Party (1773); the Coercive Acts and First Continental Congress (1774); and Lexington and Concord (April 1775). The core grievance was taxation without representation and control over colonial self-government.

Common misconceptions

- The colonists' objection was to being taxed without consent, and to loss of self-government — not simply to any tax.
- The Boston Massacre killed five and was used as propaganda; it was not a large battle.
- Parliament had compromised before (repealing the Stamp Act in 1766); by 1774 it did not.

Vocabulary

Proclamation of 1763, Stamp Act, Townshend Acts, Boston Massacre, Coercive/Intolerable Acts, First Continental Congress, Minutemen, boycott.

Historical context

Proclamation Oct. 1763; Stamp Act 1765; Townshend Acts 1767; Boston Massacre March 5, 1770; Boston Tea Party Dec. 16, 1773; Coercive Acts & First Continental Congress 1774; Lexington and Concord April 19, 1775.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Which link in the chain did the most to make war unavoidable? Support your claim with evidence from at least two sources and two links.